

Sohinee Bera

PhD Candidate in the Department of Communication at Cornell University

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EDUCATION

- Cornell University**
- 2022 – Present PhD Candidate in Science, Health, Risk, and Environmental Communication
Committee: Bruce V. Lewenstein (chair), Jeff Niederdeppe, Katherine McComas, & Mohan Dutta
Dissertation Title: Entangled Care: How Policy, Data, and Inequality Shape Community Health Care in Rural India
- 2025 **Cornell University**
M.S. in Science, Health, Risk, and Environmental Communication
- Purdue University**
- 2020 B.S. in Agricultural Communication
Honors Thesis: The Sociology of Trust in Science: Evaluating and Predicting Levels of Scientism in Indiana Residents. *The Journal of Purdue Undergraduate Research*, 11(2021), 13-22. doi.org/10.7771/2158-4052.1490

PUBLICATIONS

Journal Articles

- Bera, S.**, Salazar De Leon, C., Lewenstein, B. V. (2026). Insights for Inclusive Upstream Engagement with Migrant Farmworkers in Agriculture: A case study from the US-Mexico border. *Ambio: A Journal of Environment and Society*. doi.org/10.1007/s13280-026-02383-1
- Vilchez, A., **Bera, S.**, Lewenstein, B., Hilgartner, S., (2026). Examining media coverage of ethical dimensions of advanced algorithmic technology. *Public Understanding of Science*. 35(5), 557-575. doi.org/10.1177/09636625261419755
- Bera, S.**, Vilchez, A., Muenster, R. (2025). Environmental issues are a global issue -but do environmental communication journals reflect this? A publication review of environmental communication scholarship. *Frontiers in Communication*. (9), 1-15. doi.org/10.3389/fcomm.2024.1474619

Book Reviews

- Bera, S.** Beyond Straw Men: Plastic Pollution and Networked Cultures of Care by P. Pezzulo. *International Journal of Communication*, 20(2026), 1545-1547. doi.org/10.65476/qbrz0774

Under review

- Bera, S.**, Gruber, A., Benevento, S., Li, C., Salazar De Leon, C., Moose, S. P., Bigman-Galimore, C., Lewenstein, B. *Who sees what* in programmable plants? Public imaginaries of emerging agriculture biotechnologies. Under review at *Journal of Agricultural and Environmental Ethics*.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

- May 2026 **Bera, S.**, When Health Work Becomes Data Work: The (In)Visibility of Community Health Workers in Rural India. *International Communication Association*. Capetown, South Africa.
- May 2026 **Bera, S.**, Gruber, A., Benevento, S., Li, C., Salazar De Leon, C., Moose, S. P., Bigman-Galimore, C., Lewenstein, B. *Who sees what* in programmable plants? Public imaginaries of emerging agriculture biotechnologies. *International Communication Association*. Capetown, South Africa.

- November 2025 **Bera, S.**, Gruber, A., Salazar de Leon., C. When Slow Foods Meet Fast Technologies. *National Communication Association*. Denver, Colorado
- May 2025 **Bera, S.** Inclusive Public Egnagement with U.S. Migrant Farmworkers: Criteria and Challenges. *Public Communication of Science and Technology Network*. Aberdeen, Scotland.
- December 2024 **Bera, S.**, Salazar De Leon, C., Voices from the Fields: Migrant Farmworker’s Perspectives on Emerging Plant Biotechnologies and Insights for Engaging Hard-to-Reach Populations. *Society for Risk Analysis*. Austin, Texas.
- September 2024 Gruber, A., **Bera, S.**, Salazar De Leon., C. (2024, September). Programmable Plants for a Sustainable Future. *Slow Foods: Terra Madre*. Turin, Italy.
- April 2024 **Bera, S.** “You can lead a horse to water, but you can't make him drink”: the unheard sanitation discourses of the Swachh Bharat Mission in India. *Public Communication of Science and Technology Network*, Zacatecas, Mexico.
- May 2023 **Bera, S.**, Vilchez, A., Muenster, R., Environmental issues are global issues – but do environmental communication journals reflect this? A publication review. *International Communication Association*, Toronto, Canada.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

2023-2025 Social Science Researcher

Center for Research on Programmable Plant Systems, Cornell University

- Lead multiple social science research projects examining public perceptions and ethical considerations surrounding emerging agricultural biotechnologies as part of the Social and Ethical Engagement Team
- Designed survey instruemnts and conducted qualitative and quantitative data collection with stakeholders such as migrant farmworkers, Black small-holder growers, agricultural professionals, and the public
- Analyzed qualitative data in MaxQDA and quantitative data in R, including thematic coding, intercoder reliability testing, and regression analyses
- Synthesized findings into two journal manuscripts (one published, one under review), 10+ conference and meeting presentations, and accessible graphic comics for the public

JAN – MAY 2024 Graduate Research Assistant

Ethics-in-the-Making (NSF Project), Cornell University

PIs: Dr. Bruce Lewenstein & Dr. Steve Hilgartener

- Co-conducted qualitative content analysis examining media coverage of ethicial issues in artificial intelligence, machine learning, and data science
- Coded, analyzed, and interpreted 150+ articles using thematic analysis and grounded theory
- Synthesized findings into co-authored publication

JAN – AUG 2023 Graduate Research Assistant

2022 Collaborative Midterm Survey (NSF Project), Cornell University

PIs: Dr. Jonathon Schuldt & Dr. Peter Enns

- Supported a collaborative survey research project examining the 2022 U.S. midterm elections and developing transparent, innovative, and cost-effective survey strategies

- Disseminated survey findings through data visualizations and graphic communication materials
- Promoted use of publicly available survey data for researchers and stakeholders

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Fall 2025	COMM 2450: Communication and Technology <i>Teaching Assistant</i>
Summer 2025	COMM 2850: Communication, Environment, Science, and Health <i>Instructor of Record</i>
Summer 2023	COMM 2850: Communication, Environment, Science, and Health <i>Instructor of Record</i>
Spring 2023	COMM 2850: Communication, Environment, Science, and Health <i>Teaching Assistant</i>
Fall 2022	COMM 2450: Communication and Technology <i>Teaching Assistant</i>

FELLOWSHIPS, GRANTS, & HONORS

Spring 2026	SUNY Provost's Diversity Fellowship (\$17,830)
Spring 2026	U.S. Department of Education & Cornell's South Asia Program: FLAS Fellowship (\$17,830, <i>declined</i>)
Fall 2025	CSSS Qualitative and Interpretive Research Institute Small Research Grant (\$2,000)
Fall 2025	Waterhouse Family Institute Research Grant (\$5,688)
Spring 2025	Community Access and Outreach Award for Impact on Communities Beyond Cornell for GRASSHOPR
Summer 2024	Visiting Scholar at Joshua Tree National Park
Fall 2022	Cornell Fellowship (\$36,684)
2022	Cornell Graduate School Dean's Scholars
2021- 2022	U.S. Fulbright Grantee, English Teaching Assistant in Germany (\$11,330)

MENTORSHIP & ENGAGEMENT

May – August 2026	Supervised and trained undergraduate research assistant in transcription of Bengali-language interviews, including instruction in IRB compliance, research ethics, and qualitative methods. Cornell University, Ithaca, NY
June 2025	Co-led science communication workshop with visiting REU students. Cornell University, Ithaca, NY
July 2024 – August 2024	Developed “Introduction to Social Science” crash course for visiting REU students. Cornell University, Ithaca, NY
July 2024	Co-led science communication workshops with visiting REU students & CURIE Academy high school students. Cornell University, Ithaca, NY
June 2024 – August 2024	Mentored REU student and supervised research on public perceptions of genetically modified organisms. Cornell University, Ithaca, NY.

MEDIA COVERAGE

October 2025	Research featured in exhibit “Hello, Human! The Emerging Science of Plant Communication and Smart Agriculture.” Mann Gallery, Cornell University, Ithaca, NY
March 2025	Quoted in the <i>Cornell Chronicle</i> article “ From Lab to Learning: Grad Students Bring Hands-On Science to NYS Classrooms ”

January 2025	Quoted in the <i>Cornell Chronicle</i> article “ Communicating with CROPPS Research in Arizona ”
January 2025	Interviewed for a segment on engaging migrant farmworkers for <i>Science IRL</i> video. “ How a Giant Robot & Red Light Can Save Plants from Climate Change .”

INVITED TALKS

May 2025	Presentation on “Growing Responsibly: Internal and External Visions of Emerging Plant Biotechnologies” for CROPPS NSF Site Visit. Cornell University. Ithaca, NY.
March 2024	Presentation on “Embedded Social Science in Public Engagement Case study” to CROPPS Scientific and Industrial Advisory Board. Online.
October 2023	Presentation on “Public Engagement Criteria and Evaluation” at CROPPS annual meeting at University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign, IL
March 2023	Guest lecture on “Negotiations of India’s Swachh Bharat Mission” for COMM 2850 (Communication Science, Health, and Environment). Cornell University, Ithaca, NY

SERVICE & COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT

- 2022 – 2026 **Graduate Student School Outreach Program (GRASSHOPR)**
- Fellow (2022-24), Treasurer (2023-24), Vice President (2024-2026)
 - Facilitated course development and applications from graduate students to match student-developed ‘mini’ courses with local K-12 teachers
 - Developed two-week course for local elementary students on ecological ways of knowing and discovering nature and art in everyday life
- 2023-2024 **Communication Graduate Student Association** (Vice President)
- Secured \$1,500 in additional external funding for graduate student programming
 - Organized and led professional development workshops and social events to support graduate student community
 - Helped serve as student liaison to department chair and director of graduate studies, representing graduate student interests and concerns

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

- 2021-2022 **U.S. Fulbright Grantee**
English Teaching, Geschwister-Scholl Realschule Plus, Andernach, Germany
- Supported English instruction in 12 classes a week from grades 5-10
 - Developed culturally relevant and engaging lessons on topics related to American culture, current events, history, holidays, and English grammar
 - Fostered community and inclusion as a Diversity Placement at a school with significant population of refugee and immigrant students
- 2021 **Visitor Damage Mitigation Intern**
Joshua Tree National Park, CA
- Mapped, monitored, and restored illegal off-highway vehicle incursions, graffiti, and other instances of visitor damage to sensitive desert ecological and cultural resources to protect and preserve the park
 - Developed a mitigation plan on visitor impacts to best concentrate restoration efforts, ensure future sustainable recreation, and address future impacts of climate change

SKILLS

Qual. Research Interviews, focus groups, thematic analysis, grounded theory, textual analysis

Quan. Research	Surveys, media content analysis, R, Qualtrics
Graphic Design	Adobe Photoshop, Illustrator, Premiere Pro
Languages	English (native), Bengali (native), German (proficient)

REFERENCES

Dr. Bruce V. Lewenstein

Professor of Science Communication & Science and Technology Studies
 Cornell University
b.lewenstein@cornell.edu
 Relationship: Committee Chair

Dr. Katherine McComas

Professor of Risk Communication
 Cornell University
kam19@cornell.edu
 Relationship: Committee Member

Dr. Jeff Niederdeppe

Professor of Health Communication & Public Policy
 Cornell University
jdn@56@cornell.edu
 Relationship: Committee Member
